

POTATOES *Solanum tuberosum*

Potatoes are a useful, adaptable kitchen vegetable, and easy to grow, even in small spaces. They are sometimes classified by how long they take to mature: new potatoes, the smallest, sweetest types, should be lifted first; midseason potatoes can be harvested shortly after; and late season potatoes, which take the longest to mature, produce tubers that are best for winter storage.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
PLANT				
HARVEST				

CHITTING

Although it is not absolutely necessary, chitting your potatoes before you plant them out will give you a headstart, and should result in a quicker harvest. Place your seed potatoes, with their “eyes” facing upward, in trays or egg cartons in a warm, light location. They will sprout short, green shoots or “chits.” Move them to a cooler position about six weeks before planting, when the chits are .25–.5 in (5–10 mm) long.

PLANTING

Potatoes prefer an open, sunny, frost-free site in well-drained soil with a pH of 5–6. Practice crop rotation, and do not plant your crop where you have grown



Plant chitted potatoes “eyes” up.

potatoes, onions, or other root vegetables the previous year.

Dig some organic matter, such as compost or well-rotted manure, into the soil in the fall before planting. Just before you plant, apply a balanced fertilizer on the soil surface and work it in well. Alternatively, spread fertilizer along the rows when planting.

In spring, once there's no risk of severe frost, plant your